hiding. He was defeated twice in succession, the first time in June near Perth, the second time on August 11 at Dalry, much deeper into Scottish territory. His men were forced into hiding, and Bruce himself became a fugitive, living "a most wretched life in the wilderness," as the *Chronicle of Pluscarden* tells us:

> He sometimes went a whole fortnight without taking any food but raw herbs, water and milk . . . now walking barefoot when his shoes were worn out with age; now left alone in the islands; now alone, unknown, fleeing from his enemies; now slighted and despised by his own servants, he remained utterly deserted, an outcast from all his acquaintances.[5]

But he remained out of English hands, and while Bruce was at large, the Scots still hoped for victory.

EDWARD I WAS ILL. He had been slow to arrive at the Scottish front, after Bruce's coronation, because he was suffering from pains in his legs and his neck and could ride only two miles per day. He grew a little stronger over the winter, but the illness returned in the summer of 1307. He was on his way back to Scotland when he came down with dysentery; already weakened, he died suddenly on July 6, while his servants were getting him out of bed for breakfast. It was his thirty-fifth year as king of England.[6]

The Prince of Wales was crowned Edward II of England, and almost at once Bruce emerged from the shadows and began to regather his armies. Scotland's fortunes took a sharp turn towards the good; Edward II was less concerned with Robert Bruce than with arranging the royal household to suit himself. He was, says the contemporary *Vita Edwardi Secundi*, "a strong young man in about his twenty-third year . . . [who] did not fulfil his father's ambition, but turned his mind to other things."[7]

One of his first acts as king was to call back, from exile, his close friend Piers Gaveston. Gaveston and Edward II had grown up together, and the two young men had become so inseparable that the older Edward grew annoyed: "He realized that his son, the prince of Wales, loved a certain Gascon knight well beyond measure," remarks the fourteenth-century *Annales Paulini*. When the Prince of Wales demanded that Gaveston be given the title Count of Ponthieu (a Norman countship that had belonged to Edward I himself), the king flew into a fury and banished Gaveston to his ancestral lands in Gascony,* a southwestern French province controlled by the English crown.† Young Edward was forced to swear that he would "neither receive, nor keep with him nor about him" the banished knight, and on his deathbed Edward I